



**TITLE:**

**Project Dashboards in Industrial  
EPC Projects: Designing for  
Decision, Not Decoration**

**Athor:**

**Behzad Mousavi, MSc in Industrial Engineering  
Planning & Project Control Specialist**

## **Abstract**

**In industrial EPC contracting, project dashboards are often mistaken for aesthetic exercises—colorful charts and gauges that look impressive in meetings but fail to drive action. A true dashboard is not a report; it is a decision-support interface designed to surface critical signals, suppress noise, and align stakeholders around shared reality. This article presents a comprehensive framework for designing, implementing, and sustaining effective project dashboards tailored to oil, gas, and petrochemical projects. Drawing on 25+ years of field experience in Iran’s energy sector, we introduce methodologies for selecting meaningful metrics, structuring visual hierarchy, integrating live data sources, and avoiding common design traps that render dashboards useless. Whether serving executives, project managers, or discipline leads, this guide provides the blueprint for transforming static visuals into dynamic intelligence that accelerates decisions and protects project outcomes.**

### **1. Introduction: The Dashboard Illusion**

**Industrial projects generate overwhelming data volumes. In response, organizations build dashboards filled with S-curves, CPI/SPI gauges, milestone trackers, and risk heatmaps. Yet, most fail to deliver value because they prioritize presentation over purpose.**

**Common failures include:**

- **Vanity Metrics:** Highlighting favorable numbers while burying critical risks in appendices.
- **Information Overload:** Cramming 30+ KPIs onto one screen, paralyzing rather than informing.
- **Static Data:** Screenshots updated weekly manually, creating lag between reality and display.
- **Audience Agnosticism:** Same dashboard shown to CEO and site supervisor despite vastly different needs.
- **No Action Linkage:** Beautiful visuals with no clear next steps or ownership when thresholds breach.

**These practices don’t enhance management—they simulate it. In high-stakes environments like South Pars or Assaluyeh, where delays cost millions per day, decorative dashboards are expensive distractions.**

This article moves beyond graphic design to establish a decision-centric, audience-specific, and dynamically integrated dashboard system. Our focus is on creating interfaces that don't just show status—but trigger timely, informed action.

## 2. Principles of Effective Dashboard Design

Before building any visualization, adhere to these foundational principles:

### Principle 1: Audience-First Architecture

Every dashboard must answer: “What does *this* user need to decide *right now*?” Tailor rigorously:

| Audience                     | Primary Question                                          | Dashboard Focus                                                        |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Executives / Client          | Are we on track? What threatens success?                  | Top 5 KPIs, trend direction, escalation items, financial exposure      |
| Project Manager              | Where are bottlenecks? What requires my intervention?     | Integrated cross-functional view, variance root causes, resource gaps  |
| Discipline Leads             | Is my team performing?<br>What's blocking progress?       | Detailed operational metrics, backlog aging, quality/safety alerts     |
| Contractors / Subcontractors | Am I meeting expectations?<br>What approvals are pending? | Certified progress, open RFIs/VOs, payment status, coordination points |

Never use universal templates. Customize depth, language, and emphasis per role.

### Principle 2: Signal-to-Noise Ratio Optimization

Dashboards have limited cognitive bandwidth. Apply ruthless prioritization:

- Limit to  $7 \pm 2$  core metrics (Miller's Law).
- Use pre-attentive attributes (color, size, position) to highlight exceptions—not decorate.
- Suppress stable metrics; amplify deviations.
- Provide drill-down paths for detail seekers without cluttering primary view.

Clarity beats completeness. If everything is highlighted, nothing is.

### Principle 3: Contextual Anchoring

Raw numbers lack meaning. Always embed reference points:

- Baseline vs. Actual vs. Forecast comparisons.

- **Threshold bands (Green/Amber/Red) defined contractually or statistically.**
- **Trend indicators (sparklines, arrows) showing momentum.**
- **Peer/historical benchmarks for relative assessment.**

**A CPI of 0.92 means nothing alone. With context (“down from 1.04 last month; below 0.95 threshold”), it demands attention.**

#### **Principle 4: Action-Oriented Structure**

**Design for response, not passive consumption:**

- **Lead with conclusions, not data exploration.**
- **Pair every red metric with owner name and due date for corrective action.**
- **Include “Next Steps” section with specific, assignable tasks.**
- **Enable direct navigation to supporting details or source systems.**

**If a dashboard doesn’t prompt action within 60 seconds of viewing, redesign it.**

### **3. Core Dashboard Components for Industrial EPC**

**Based on decades of field experience, effective dashboards integrate these elements:**

#### **Executive Summary Panel**

**Top-of-screen snapshot answering strategic questions:**

- **Overall Health Rating (RAG + narrative justification).**
- **Schedule/Cost Forecast vs. Baseline (P50/P80 ranges).**
- **Top 3 Risks Requiring Attention (with mitigation status).**
- **Key Milestones Next 30 Days (on-track/at-risk/delayed).**
- **Cash Flow Position & Liquidity Outlook.**

**Critical Rule: Limit to  $\leq 1$  screen height. Scrolling = failure.**

#### **Integrated Performance Matrix**

**Cross-functional KPI grid enabling rapid scanning:**

| Dimension    | Metric              | Current | Trend                                                                             | Target | Status                                                                              |
|--------------|---------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Schedule     | SPI                 | 0.89    |  | ≥0.95  |  |
| Cost         | CPI                 | 0.94    | →                                                                                 | ≥0.98  |  |
| Engineering  | Approval Cycle Time | 18d     |  | ≤10d   |                                                                                     |
| Procurement  | PO On-Time %        | 72%     |  | ≥90%   |  |
| Construction | Physical Progress   | 68%     |  | 75%    |  |
| HSE          | TRIR                | 0.8     | →                                                                                 | ≤1.0   |  |

Use consistent color coding. Add sparklines in “Trend” column for instant pattern recognition.

### Variance Deep-Dive Module

For metrics breaching thresholds:

- Quantified impact (time/cost/risk).
- Root cause diagnosis (not symptom description).
- Corrective action plan with owner/deadline.
- Recovery trajectory forecast.

Avoid generic explanations. Specify: “Piping fabrication delayed 12 days due to welder shortage; recovery via weekend shifts starting [date]; net impact: 8-day slippage.”

### Forward Look & Risk Radar

Predictive section preventing surprises:

- Upcoming milestones with dependency map.
- Emerging risks with probability/impact matrix.
- Resource constraints anticipated (labor/equipment/materials).
- Interface/coordinations required across teams.

Frame as proactive management—not passive forecasting.

### Supporting Detail Tabs

On-demand access without clutter:

- Detailed schedule extracts (critical path only).
- Cost breakdown by WBS/account.
- Engineering deliverable status log.
- Procurement tracker snapshot.
- Inspection/test reports summary.

Label clearly. Reference in main body where relevant.

#### **4. Dashboard Implementation Framework**

Sustainable dashboards require disciplined governance:

##### **Step 1: Requirements Workshop**

Co-design with end-users:

- Map decisions each audience makes weekly/monthly.
- Identify current pain points in existing reporting.
- Define success criteria: “Dashboard succeeds if X decision improves by Y%.”
- Prioritize metrics based on decision impact, not data availability.

Build what users need—not what data exists.

##### **Step 2: Data Integration Strategy**

Ensure reliability and timeliness:

- Automate feeds from P6, ERP, DMS, field apps.
- Validate at source; never trust manual entry.
- Establish refresh SLAs (executive: daily; ops: real-time).
- Document data lineage for auditability.

Garbage in = garbage out. Accuracy is non-negotiable.

##### **Step 3: Visual Design & Prototyping**

Test before deployment:

- Create low-fidelity wireframes for feedback.
- Conduct usability testing with target users.

- Iterate based on comprehension speed and action clarity.
- Ensure mobile/tablet responsiveness.

**Beauty serves function—not vice versa.**

#### **Step 4: Governance & Evolution**

**Maintain relevance over time:**

- Quarterly review: Retire unused metrics; add emerging needs.
- Track adoption: Login frequency, dwell time, action completion rates.
- Solicit continuous feedback via embedded surveys.
- Update thresholds/baselines at phase gates or change orders.

**Dashboards decay without care. Treat as living products.**

#### **5. Common Pitfalls & Mitigation Strategies**

**Even well-intentioned dashboards fail due to behavioral factors:**

| <b>Pitfall</b>              | <b>Consequence</b>                                  | <b>Mitigation Strategy</b>                                      |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Metric Proliferation</b> | <b>Cognitive overload; key signals lost</b>         | <b>Enforce 7±2 rule; retire metrics quarterly</b>               |
| <b>Gaming Behavior</b>      | <b>Teams optimize metric, not outcome</b>           | <b>Pair with qualitative audits; reward ethical performance</b> |
| <b>Data Silos</b>           | <b>Inconsistent definitions across departments</b>  | <b>Centralized metric dictionary with approved formulas</b>     |
| <b>Static Targets</b>       | <b>Goals become irrelevant as project evolves</b>   | <b>Review/target-adjust at major phase gates</b>                |
| <b>Blame Culture</b>        | <b>Fear of red metrics leads to hiding problems</b> | <b>Frame as diagnostic tools, not punishment mechanisms</b>     |

**Golden Rule: If a dashboard doesn't change behavior or trigger decisions, it's decoration—not management tool. Measure success by stakeholder engagement, not distribution volume.**

#### **6. Digital Enablement: From Static PDFs to Dynamic Intelligence**

**Traditional static dashboards are obsolete. Prioritize digital solutions offering:**

- **Live Data Feeds:** Real-time integration from multiple systems.
- **Interactive Filtering:** Drill-down, slice-by-discipline/area/subcontractor.
- **Automated Alerts:** Push notifications when thresholds breach.
- **Collaborative Annotation:** Comment directly on metrics with action tracking.
- **Version Control:** Audit trail of changes; historical comparison.

**Digital dashboards transform passive consumption into active engagement.**

## **7. Case Study: Restoring Confidence Through Purpose-Built Dashboards**

**On a \$580M refinery upgrade in Bandar Abbas, monthly dashboards were dense, optimistic, and consistently late. Client stopped trusting numbers; payments delayed; relationship deteriorated. Dashboards showed SPI=0.95 while site reality was 3-month slippage.**

### **Intervention:**

- 1. Co-designed new dashboard format with client representatives; focused on their decision needs.**
- 2. Automated data integration from P6, ERP, and QA systems; eliminated manual entry.**
- 3. Instituted “No Surprises” policy: Bad news reported immediately with recovery plan.**
- 4. Added predictive section showing 30/60/90-day outlook with confidence levels.**
- 5. Established post-dashboard debrief calls to clarify ambiguities and gather feedback.**

### **Results After 4 Months:**

- **Dashboard delivery improved from Day 10 to Day 3 of month-end.**
- **Client payment certification resumed with zero queries.**
- **Joint problem-solving sessions replaced adversarial meetings.**
- **Project recovered 2.5 months through early issue identification enabled by transparent dashboards.**

**This turnaround wasn’t about prettier graphics—it was about rebuilding trust through honesty, timeliness, and relevance.**

## **8. Conclusion: Dashboards as Decision Interfaces**



**Project dashboards are not reporting artifacts; they are decision interfaces codified. They shape perceptions, build trust, align expectations, and drive collective action. Poor dashboards isolate teams; excellent dashboards integrate them.**

**Design empathetically. Visualize ruthlessly. Integrate dynamically. Evolve continuously. And remember: the goal isn't flawless visuals—it's better decisions.**

**Your dashboard is your project's command center. Make it clear, make it credible, and make it compelling.**

**For more technical articles, training materials, and professional resources, visit our page in GitHub as a link below:**

- <https://sbmousavices.github.io/industrial-Tools>

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